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ARTICLE

When Apostate Pastors Make Disciples: The Dangerous Legacy of Progressives



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Lea



BY PNW STAFF JUNE 03, 2026

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Every generation leaves a spiritual inheritance to the next. Faithful pastors pass on sound doctrine, a love for God's Word, and a commitment to biblical truth. But what happens when pastors abandon those foundations? What happens when church leaders begin treating Scripture as something to be corrected, edited, or explained away rather than believed?

The answer is now playing out in real time across America.

One of the clearest examples may be found in Austin, Texas, where progressive pastor Jim Rigby has spent decades reshaping Christianity according to modern cultural values. Now one of his most prominent disciples, Texas politician James Talarico, is taking those same ideas beyond the walls of the church and into the public square as he runs for the Senate.

This is how theological drift works. It rarely stops with one pastor. Ideas reproduce. Beliefs spread. Teachers make disciples who become teachers themselves.

And eventually entire generations inherit the consequences.

The recent profile of Rigby and Talarico reveals far more than a simple pastor-congregant relationship. It provides a window into how progressive Christianity trains the next generation to embrace a faith that increasingly bears little resemblance to historic biblical Christianity.

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Imagine that for a moment.

The Apostle Paul was not merely an influential Christian thinker. He was chosen by Christ, inspired by the Holy Spirit, and responsible for much of the New Testament. Through his writings, God gave the church foundational doctrines concerning salvation, grace, sanctification, marriage, church leadership, and Christian living.

Yet in this congregation, one of Christianity's greatest apostles is openly ridiculed.

This should alarm every Bible-believing Christian.

The problem is not merely disrespect toward Paul. The problem is what such attitudes reveal about the authority of Scripture itself. Once believers are taught that biblical authors were morally defective, culturally backward, or fundamentally wrong on important issues, it becomes easy to dismiss any biblical teaching that conflicts with modern values.

The authority shifts from God's Word to human opinion.

That shift becomes even more evident when examining Rigby's theology.

He reportedly avoids referring to God as "Lord." He avoids masculine pronouns for God. He says he does not particularly care for the word "God" itself. In sermons, he has referred instead to a vague "creative impulse of the universe."



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This language may sound spiritual, but it is a far cry from the God revealed in Scripture.

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Yet, as the church moves forward, the consequences of these progressive ideas will become increasingly evident.

The consequences become evident in the positions being promoted.

Rigby played a significant role in pushing his denomination toward affirming same-sex relationships. His church has hosted ceremonies affirming transgender identities. The church uses an "Inclusive Bible" that alters traditional wording in an effort to accommodate modern ideological concerns.

What began as theological accommodation has become theological transformation.

And now those same ideas are appearing in politics through figures like Talarico.

Talarico frequently frames progressive political positions using biblical language. He has argued for abortion rights using the story of Mary. He has promoted interpretations of Scripture that critics say blur or redefine biblical understandings of gender. He regularly presents progressive political priorities as natural extensions of Christian teaching.

This is precisely why doctrine matters.

Ideas have consequences.

What pastors teach on Sunday eventually shapes what leaders advocate on Monday.

When pastors teach that Scripture is flexible, politicians learn to use Scripture as a tool to support whatever cultural cause they favor. When pastors question biblical authority, future leaders become comfortable reinterpreting God's Word to fit contemporary ideologies.

A generation ago, many Christians assumed progressive theology would remain confined to declining mainline denominations.

They were wrong.

The influence of these ideas now extends through social media, seminaries, universities, political movements, and increasingly visible public figures who speak the language of Christianity while redefining its content.

Perhaps the most sobering aspect of this story is that Rigby himself expressed delight at seeing Talarico "taking the ideas out there."

That statement captures the heart of the issue.

Every pastor is making disciples.

Every church is producing a next generation.

The question is not whether ideas are being passed down. The question is which ideas are being passed down.

Will the next generation inherit a faith anchored in the authority of Scripture, the lordship of Jesus Christ, and the historic truths of the Gospel?



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The progressive pastor will tell you that he is not a pastor, but a prophet. He will tell them what they want to hear (2 Timothy 4:3).

That warning feels increasingly relevant today.

The church's greatest threat has never been opposition from outside. It has always been corruption from within.

And when apostate pastors train the next generation, the damage rarely ends with one congregation. It spreads into institutions, communities, and even governments.

That is why Christians must remain vigilant.

Because today's progressive pastor may be producing tomorrow's influential leader.

And what is planted in the pulpit today may shape an entire culture tomorrow.

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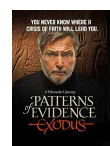
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